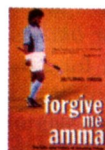


A Stick in Time

The portrait of a tempestuous legend leaves little to allusion



FORGIVE ME AMMA: THE LIFE AND TIMES OF DHANRAJ PILLAY

by SUNDEEP MISRA

Wisdom Tree

Price: Rs 395; Pages: 249

■ By Sharda Ugra

If you ever need to understand why hockey has been bumped off the government's priority sports list, start here. The unauthorised biography of Dhanraj Pillay, an icon of the game both at home and abroad, is meant to be a portrait of a tempestuous genius. But it also sets out the landscape in which the Indian hockey team operates, which in turn explains why we are the way we are.

Even during the team's slide, Pillay remained a talisman, prima donna and patriot, saviour and sinner, man of the match and villain of the piece. Misra takes the chronological route through his career to try to find a cohesion in the work and play of this most changeable of men.

The book could have done with a vigilant editor to encourage the author's broader brushstrokes. A long-time hockey reporter, Misra has insight into people and access to information. It is in here, rather than in the game-day narration, that the book, Pillay and Indian hockey acquire breath.

The author tries to fathom Pillay behind the theatrics and provides an unsparing account of the envy he generated among his teammates because of his popularity. Little is left to allusion: the arrogance of coaches, the IHF's utter lack of integrity or foresight.

He writes, "(Indian hockey players) come up (*sic*) ... seeing politics in team selection. The moment they see a person with a spine, they tend to rally around him." No wonder the IHF ensures no coach or player gets too popular. Is this all Byzantine, bizarre or just an airing of dirty linen? It doesn't matter. After *Forgive Me Amma*, the mind-bender is working out how the Indian team actually manages to keep it all together and win sometimes. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Inheritance of Loss	Kiran Desai	Penguin
2. (2)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Penguin
3. (3)	Like the Flowing River	Paulo Coelho	HarperCollins
4. (4)	The Namesake	Jhumpa Lahiri	HarperCollins
5. (-)	The Children of Hurin	J.R.R. Tolkien	HarperCollins

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (-)	It Happened in India	Kishore Biyani, Dipayan Baishya	Rupa
2. (5)	The Indians: Portrait of a People	Sudhir Kakar and Katharina Kakar	Penguin
3. (3)	The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
4. (8)	Dhirubhaism	A.G. Krishnamurthy	Tata McGraw-Hill
5. (11)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
9. (6)	Above Average	Amitabha Bagchi	HarperCollins
11. (-)	Tall, Dark and Handsome	Nisha Minhas	Pocket
13. (19)	The Alchemy of Desire	Tarun J. Tejpal	HarperCollins
17. (-)	Chowringhee	Shankar	Penguin
19. (17)	By Which We See All Colours	Mrinalini Patwardhan Mehra	Full Circle

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (-)	Dabbawalas	Shrinivas Pandit	Tata McGraw-Hill
7. (-)	Planet India	Mira Kamdar	Scribner
8. (9)	The Greatness Guide	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
9. (6)	Mohandas: A True Story of a Man, his People and an Empire	Rajmohan Gandhi	Penguin

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead